

STRAWBERRIES *Fragaria x ananassa*

Picked and eaten fresh from the garden, served up with cream and meringue, or used for jams and desserts, strawberries are the quintessential summer treat. They are classified according to their fruiting habits: June-bearing; everbearing, which produce a crop through into fall; and day-neutral, which will grow at any time of year, provided that you give them the right amounts of warmth and protection.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Although it is possible to grow strawberries from seed, it is much easier to buy healthy, disease-free plants or runners. Runners will either be fresh and dug up just before purchase, or will have been cold-stored—kept at just below freezing point until they are thawed out and ready to sell.

Plant out summer-fruiting and perpetual types mid- to late summer; plant cold-stored runners in late spring, fresh June-bearing or everbearing plants in fall, and day-neutral types at any time of year. Strawberries prefer a sunny, frost-free site with free-draining soil, and they will tolerate slightly acidic conditions. They can also be grown in a variety of



Firm plants in gently after planting.

containers (see tip box on p.119). Dig in well-rotted manure or compost before planting to improve the soil structure and increase fertility. Ensure that crops have enough space—they need about 18 in (45 cm) between plants, and about 30 in (75 cm) between rows. When planting, ensure that the crowns of the plants are kept above soil level, and water in well. Strawberries